HILCHOT SHABBAT

Hot Water, Haircuts & Nails: Washing for Shabbat

Given Thursday 12 November 2026 · Hilchot Shabbat | Siman 260

Sefer: Shulhan Arukh, Orah Hayim, Hilchot Shabbat **Siman:** 260, seifim 1-2 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Thursday Hilchot Shabbat class, Thursday 8 June 2023

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Where we are

After a break for Shavuot, the class moved on to siman 260, the laws of bringing in Shabbat. The chapters in between, on leaving food on the fire from before Shabbat, will be learned together with the laws of cooking (Bishul) when we reach them.

So far: we have done the shopping and spent on Shabbat (242), stopped work in time (251) and prepared the food (250). Now we prepare ourselves.

Seif 1: washing in hot water

The Shulhan Arukh: it is a misvah to wash one's face, hands and feet in hot water on Friday, to wash the hair, and to cut the nails.

The Rema, in the small print, adds "the whole body", and the way it is printed you might think that is what the Shulhan Arukh means. It is not. The Gemara says face, hands and feet; washing the whole body is the Rema's addition.

Practical points: - **At the very least,** if you come home late and have no time for a shower, wash your face and hands with soap and freshen your hair. - **Feet:** the Mishnah Berurah notes that we are not careful about this today. In their day people walked barefoot; we wear socks and shoes. - **Why hot water?** For the honour of Shabbat. It is pleasant to come into Shabbat washed in hot water. The Rabbi called a hot mikveh on Friday afternoon one of the greatest pleasures; in earlier times the weekly wash was scheduled for Friday. - **Women** have the same misvah, and it also applies on Erev Yom Tov. - **Thursday:** the misvah is on Friday, when it is recognisable as for Shabbat. If you showered on Thursday, it is good to wash again on Friday.

Priorities. This is a misvah, a nice thing, not an obligation.

"Better to come to shul on time and don't have your shower."

Do not rush to shower and risk desecrating Shabbat or missing tefillah. Tefillah is an obligation; this is not.

The bathhouse warning: combing and squeezing

The Mishnah Berurah warns about people in the winter who leave the bathhouse just before sunset and then comb their hair or wring out the towel after Shabbat has begun. Combing can pull out hair, which is a Torah prohibition (gozez, shearing). Squeezing a wet towel is sehitah, which falls under mekhabes, laundering. This is why mikvaot close well before candle lighting.

A wet towel is mukseh. A towel wet enough that water can be squeezed out of it is one of the rare examples of mukseh mehamat issur, mukseh because of the prohibition it can lead to (another example is the lulav on Shabbat during Sukkot). A towel that is only damp is not mukseh. If you used a dry towel on Shabbat to mop up a spill and it became soaking, you may move it out of the way, but not move it around freely; once it dries it is fine.

Haircuts and nails

The Rema: if your hair is long, it is a misvah to have your haircut on Friday. Cutting hair on Shabbat is the Melakhah of gozez. Nothing in halacha forbids a haircut at other times; the Kabbalists say not at night, and some avoid Rosh Hodesh based on the will of Rabbi Yehudah HaHasid, but when Rosh Hodesh falls on Friday people do. An opinion about 150 years ago that a haircut on Sunday disgraces Shabbat was not accepted.

The order of cutting nails. Everyone agrees not to cut them in order, because that is how the nails of the dead are cut at the taharah. The Rema brings an Ashkenazi order (by the sign "dbgha"), starting from a different finger on each hand. The Beer Heitev records that the Arizal mocked this, which is why Sefaradim never kept it. The Rambam would not have worried about it at all. Sefaradim simply avoid cutting in order.

Not on Thursday. The Mishnah Berurah says not to cut nails on Thursday, as they begin to grow on the third day. The Rabbi said he has never understood this and that it is an "inyan", a nice idea, not halacha.

Disposing of nails. Hazal said not to leave cut nails lying around. Some understand a mystical danger to a pregnant woman; the most simple understanding is that it is unhygienic. Therefore do not cut your nails in the changing room of the mikveh, where they go everywhere.

Looking at the nails at Havdalah. This came up as a question. Strictly, at Havdalah you only need fire in front of you and to say the berakhah. Looking at the nails is a simple way to show you benefit from the light, by distinguishing nail from flesh. You do not need to put your hands near the flame; it is enough to be in the room. If you hold the candle yourself, hold it in the right hand, as with all misvot.

Seif 2: three things to ask before Shabbat

Close to Shabbat, a man should ask his household gently: "Have you separated maaser? Have you made the eruv? Light the candle."

- **Maaser** cannot be separated on Shabbat because it changes the status of the food, which is rabbinically like makkeh bapatish (completing an item). Hallah is included here and must be separated before Shabbat.

- **Eruv** means Eruv Haserot for carrying, not Eruv Tavshilin. Today the community eruv is renewed once a year on Erev Pesah, so we do not ask each week.
- **Light the candle** is still fully relevant today. It is phrased as an instruction, after the first two have been confirmed, and means before sunset.

Ask gently. The Gemara says: speak softly so that they will accept it. "Never get your message across in an aggressive way." The Gemara also warns that a person should never impose excessive fear on his household. It tells of households where people were so afraid of an angry reaction that they lied, for example saying maaser had been separated when it had not, which led to eating untithed food, and more serious sins. A household needs discipline, but not fear.

This is still the practice: before Shabbat, tell everyone Shabbat is coming in ten minutes, check the preparations are done, and then light.

Practical summary

- It is a misvah to wash at least face and hands in hot water before Shabbat; a whole shower is a nice addition.
- If you are late, skip the shower rather than be late for shul or risk desecrating Shabbat.
- Finish combing and drying before Shabbat; do not squeeze wet towels, and a soaking towel is mukseh.
- Have a haircut and cut nails on Friday if needed; Sefaradim simply avoid cutting nails in order.
- Do not leave cut nails lying around.
- Before Shabbat, gently remind the household to finish preparations and light the candles.

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